

Summary & Main Idea — Part 1

Name: _____

Date: _____

Time: **60 min**

1 · COPY THIS DOWN — NOTES, STRUCTURES & TECHNIQUE

DEFINITION

The **main idea** is the single most important point a paragraph or passage is making — not just "what happens," but what it's really about.

TECHNIQUE — 3 STEPS

1. Read the paragraph, then cover it and try to say its point in one sentence, from memory
2. Check: does your sentence capture the point, or just one small detail?
3. Cut anything that's just an example or supporting detail, not the main point itself

MAIN IDEA VS. SUPPORTING DETAIL — COPY THE RULE

A **supporting detail** proves or illustrates the main idea but could be removed without losing the paragraph's overall point. If you could delete a sentence and the paragraph still makes its main point, it was a detail, not the main idea.

SENTENCE FRAME TO COPY

"The main idea of this [paragraph/passage] is that _____. This is supported by the detail that _____."

2 · PRACTICE — 4 PASSAGES, 20 QUESTIONS

EXTRACT A

Local allotments have quietly become one of the best places to meet neighbours. Mr. Diallo, three plots down from the entrance, learned more about his street from swapping courgettes than from ten years of nodding hello on the pavement.

1. What is the main idea of this extract?

2. What is the supporting detail?

3. Could the Mr. Diallo detail be removed and the main idea still stand? Explain.

4. Write the main idea in your own words, in one sentence.

5. Is "swapping courgettes" the main idea or an example supporting it?

EXTRACT B

Reading for just ten minutes before bed has been shown to improve sleep quality. One study found participants fell asleep on average six minutes faster than those who scrolled on their phones instead.

6. What is the main idea of this extract?

7. What is the supporting detail (the statistic)?

8. Why might a writer include a specific number like "six minutes"?

9. Summarise the whole extract in one sentence using the sentence frame.

10. If the statistic sentence were deleted, would the main idea still be clear?

EXTRACT C

The town hall clock has stopped working twice this year. Nobody has complained loudly, exactly, but three separate people have mentioned to the mayor, almost in passing, that they miss checking it on their way to work.

11. What is the main idea of this extract?

12. What is the supporting detail?

13. Is "twice this year" the main idea or a supporting fact?

14. What does the writer's choice to include three separate mentions suggest about the town's feeling?

15. Write a one-sentence summary of this whole extract.

EXTRACT D

Traffic on Elm Street has increased sharply since the new estate opened. Residents counted an extra 200 cars passing each morning compared to last year, and two near-misses at the school crossing were reported in a single week.

16. What is the main idea of this paragraph?

17. Identify two supporting details.

18. Which detail is more serious evidence for the main idea: the car count or the near-misses? Why?

19. Write the main idea using the sentence frame.

20. Could this paragraph make its main point with only one of the two details? Explain.

Apply this every time: When asked to summarise, always state the main idea first in your own words, then add only the single strongest supporting detail — never just retell everything that happens.

MARKING NOTES (FOR THE TUTOR)

1. Allotments help neighbours connect
2. Mr. Diallo's story
3. Yes — the idea would still stand generally

4. Model summary
5. Example supporting it
6. Reading before bed improves sleep

- | | |
|--|---|
| 7. The 6-minute statistic | 14. Suggests quiet, shared affection for the clock |
| 8. Adds credibility/specific evidence | 15. Model summary |
| 9. Model using frame | 16. Traffic has increased sharply since the estate opened |
| 10. Yes, though less convincing without evidence | 17. 200 extra cars; two near-misses |
| 11. People miss the working clock | 18. Near-misses — more serious/safety-related |
| 12. Three people mentioning it to the mayor | 19. Model using frame |
| 13. Supporting fact | 20. Yes, but less persuasive with only one |